

Question 16 · Unit 1 · 8 Marks

Evaluate whether HRD should be treated as a strategic function rather than only as an employee training activity.

Introduction

Evaluate means: explain both views, give arguments, mention limitations, and end with a clear judgement. The question is not 'define training'. It asks whether the organisation should place HRD at the level of strategy (like finance or marketing) or treat it as a small training activity (a calendar of courses).

Training means planned learning of job-related skills, usually for the present work. It is necessary and valuable. Strategic HRD means aligning all people-development systems — appraisal, potential, career, climate, training, OD — with the long-term goals of the organisation. The evaluation is about scope and status, not about insulting trainers.

Detailed points

- 1. What the 'training only' view looks like.** The training cell prepares an annual calendar, invites vendors, marks attendance, collects smile sheets, and reports 'so many man-days of training'. There is little link with promotion, strategy or climate. When production is busy, training is cancelled. This view treats learning as a welfare extra or a legal requirement, not as a way to win in the market.
- 2. Arguments for treating HRD as strategic.** People capability, leadership pipeline, culture and change readiness decide whether strategy can be executed. A plan to enter a new market fails if nobody can sell, serve or lead there. Nadler (1969) already defined HRD as organised learning for behavioural change, wider than a class. T.V. Rao defined a whole process of capabilities, potential and culture. Evolution of the field from personnel to strategic HRD supports this view. Human resources, unlike machines, can increase in value — that is a strategic fact.
- 3. Evidence that training-only is too narrow.** A course can have excellent content and happy participants and still leave job performance unchanged if bosses, appraisal and career systems ignore it. Skill gaps in a growing firm are not solved by one workshop. Climate problems are not solved by a lecture on motivation. Therefore reducing HRD to training under-describes what organisations actually need for effectiveness.
- 4. Counter-arguments and limits (needed for evaluation).** A very small firm may only need basic skill training and cannot afford a large HRD department. Calling every picnic 'strategic HRD' without diagnosis or results is empty fashion. Strategic status must be earned: TNA, integration, evaluation at behaviour and results levels, and a seat in business reviews. If HRD cannot talk the language of goals, it does not deserve the word strategic.
- 5. Training still remains a core instrument.** A balanced evaluation does not throw training away. Training is a major HRD subsystem. The judgement is to nest training inside a strategic system, not to replace HRD with training, and not to replace training with slogans.
- 6. Criteria for judgement.** Ask two questions. Does long-term success depend on people capability? Yes. Can isolated employee training reliably build that capability and climate? No. Therefore HRD should be treated as a strategic function.
- 7. What 'strategic HRD' would mean in practice.** HRD head involved in strategy discussions; line managers accountable for developing people; subsystems integrated; budget treated as investment; evaluation beyond attendance; culture and climate worked upon, not only courses run.
- 8. Final evaluative verdict.** Yes, HRD should be a strategic organisational function. Employee training is a vital activity within that function, not the whole of HRD. Organisations that remain at 'calendar training' will keep spending money without building the capabilities their strategy requires.

Conclusion. Give a balanced evaluation and a clear verdict: treat HRD as strategic; keep training as a strong tool inside it. Do not write that training is useless, and do not write that a training calendar equals HRD.